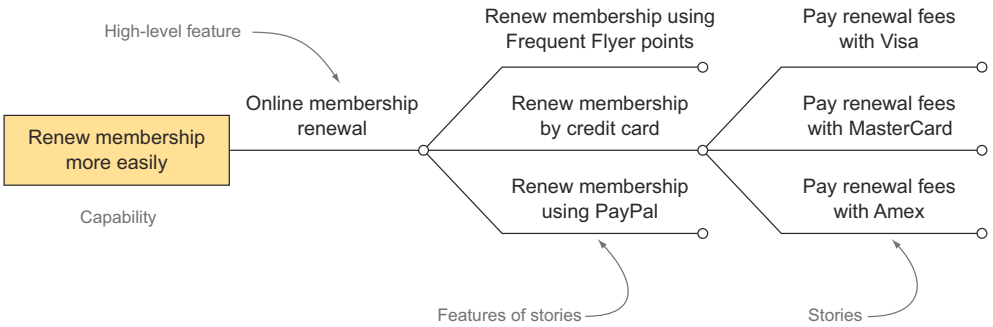


Figure 4.7 Breaking down features into smaller features or user stories makes them easier to organize and deliver.

- "Online membership renewal" would certainly qualify as a feature. If you were to deploy this feature into production by itself, it would still be of significant business value. But could you provide business value faster by incrementally delivering smaller parts of this feature, rather than waiting for it to be completely finished? This is generally a question for the business stakeholders.
- "Renew membership by credit card" would not be a feature in itself unless it included the entire renewal process. Even if it did, you'd still have to ask the project sponsor if they would be happy to deploy this feature into production without the other payment methods.
- "Pay renewal fees with Visa" and so forth would usually be considered too low-level to be delivered in isolation. Paying by Visa, for example, is just one aspect of "Renew membership by credit card," and would be of little business value in isolation. So you'd represent these in the form of user stories rather than features.

There are two main strategies when it comes to decomposing features. The one used here involves decomposing a feature into a number of smaller business processes or tasks ("Renew by credit card," "Pay with MasterCard," and so forth). You express tasks in terms of business goals and try to avoid committing to a particular implementation solution until you know more about what solution would be most appropriate. When you use this strategy, visual approaches such as Impact Mapping also make it easier to keep the larger business goals in perspective. This is generally the approach that works best when practicing BDD (and Agile in general, for that matter).

The other strategy that teams sometimes use is deciding what needs to be built early on, and coming up with user stories to deliver whatever technical solution is envisaged. This approach is risky and involves much more upfront work, with the dangers that that entails. For example, figure 4.8 shows a different decomposition of the "Membership renewal online" feature into a number of user stories.

In this decomposition, you've already imagined or designed a particular sequence of screens to implement this feature and have created user stories based on these screens. The problem is that you can lose focus on the real business goals when you